

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Thunderstorm

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Go inside a substantial building or a fully enclosed hard-top vehicle when thunder is heard. Stay away from windows and monitor warnings for damaging wind, hail, tornadoes and flash flooding.

Do now.

- ☐ **Get indoors**
01 Open shelters, tents and trees do not protect from lightning.
- ☐ **Avoid conductive paths**
02 Inside, avoid plumbing and plugged-in equipment during lightning.
- ☐ **Read new warnings**
03 Move to an interior room for severe wind or hail; use a tornado shelter if a tornado warning is issued.
- ☐ **Wait before returning**
04 After the last thunder, wait at least 30 minutes before resuming outdoor activity.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use a substantial building or enclosed hard-top vehicle even when warnings cannot be checked. Avoid plumbing and wired electrical equipment during lightning. Watch for rising water and damaging wind without going outside to observe the storm.

Watch for.

Every thunderstorm can produce lightning, even without a severe thunderstorm warning.

People & practical needs.

Account for children, older people, pets and anyone who needs assistance before moving. Keep shoes, medicines and a torch in the shelter area. Decide who helps whom and who carries the essential supplies; do not send a lone child to retrieve items. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: get indoors. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Every thunderstorm can produce lightning, even without a severe thunderstorm warning.

Keep essentials within reach.

For thunderstorm, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Use a substantial building or enclosed hard-top vehicle even when warnings cannot be checked. Avoid plumbing and wired electrical equipment during lightning. Watch for rising water and damaging wind without going outside to observe the storm. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Check for downed lines and flooded routes before travel. Schedule outdoor work around forecasts.

First decision: Get indoors

Open shelters, tents and trees do not protect from lightning. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Use a substantial building or enclosed hard-top vehicle even when warnings cannot be checked. Avoid plumbing and wired electrical equipment during lightning. Watch for rising water and damaging wind without going outside to observe the storm. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Every thunderstorm can produce lightning, even without a severe thunderstorm warning. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Go inside a substantial building or a fully enclosed hard-top vehicle when thunder is heard. Stay away from windows and monitor warnings for damaging wind, hail, tornadoes and flash flooding. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For thunderstorm, keep the specific hazard in view: Every thunderstorm can produce lightning, even without a severe thunderstorm warning.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Wait before returning. After the last thunder, wait at least 30 minutes before resuming outdoor activity. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Thunderstorm · official guidance

<https://www.weather.gov/safety/thunderstorm>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/thunderstorm/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.